

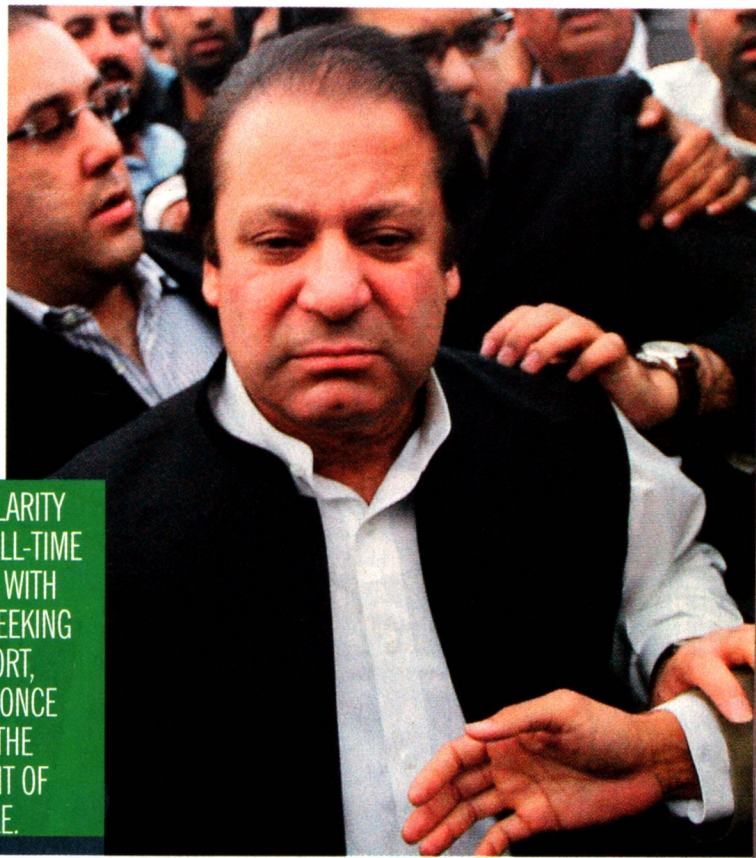
BACK TO THE FRONT

Nawaz Sharif

FORMER PRIME MINISTER

Former premier Nawaz Sharif may still be cooling his heels in Jeddah after his latest exile from Pakistan, but has seen his popularity graph shoot up because of his refusal to compromise with General Musharraf. A recent American poll found him to be the most popular political leader in Pakistan, at a time when many thought Bhutto was about to cut a deal with the embattled Pakistan President. It is widely expected that his party, the Pakistan Muslim League (N) would make substantial gains in Punjab. Sharif's near-eight years of forced exile have also clouded people's memories about his misrule, during which time his party members physically stormed the Supreme Court and another chief justice was forced to resign. Although the Americans remain deeply distrustful of his conservative streak and his close alliances with religious parties, there have also been reports of some contact between the two. The collapse of Bhutto's negotiations with Musharraf and her reaching out to Sharif may have been the best news he has heard in some time. It brings him once again to the forefront as a leading Opposition figure.

HIS POPULARITY IS AT AN ALL-TIME HIGH AND WITH BHUTTO SEEKING HIS SUPPORT, SHARIF IS ONCE AGAIN IN THE FOREFRONT OF THE BATTLE.



STRONG ARM OF THE LAW

Chaudhry Aitzaz Ahsan

PRESIDENT, Supreme Court Bar Association



Newly-elected President of the Supreme Court Bar Association, the erudite 52-year-old Chaudhry Aitzaz Ahsan has been one of the leading lights of the Pakistan Peoples Party since the end of General Zia-ul-Haq's rule. He had served as a minister during Bhutto's rule. A member of the outgoing National Assembly, he shot to greater fame when he became the lead lawyer defending Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry against the Government's reference. He managed to turn a staid legal battle into high political drama when he drove the chief justice hundreds of miles in his own car through parts of Pakistan where tumultuous crowds rallied to support a burgeoning lawyers' movement. Bhutto may have been wary of his political ambitions, especially when his views seemed at odds with her efforts for a deal with Musharraf, but seems to have accepted his opinion on supporting an independent judiciary. Arrested soon after the imposition of martial law, he is at present lodged in Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi.

HIS VIEWS IN SUPPORT OF AN INDEPENDENT JUDICIARY AND HIS ABILITY TO ROUSE LAWYERS HAVE MADE HIM A LEADING LIGHT OF THE FIGHT BACK.